Newton's second law for this motion

Gravitational force of Sun on the planet $= \frac{mv^2}{r}$

EXAMPLE 3.22

If a stone of mass 0.25 kg tied to a string executes uniform circular motion with a speed of 2 m s^{-1} of radius 3 m, what is the magnitude of tensional force acting on the stone?

Solution: $F_{cp} = \frac{mv^2}{r}$

$$F_{cp} = \frac{\frac{1}{4}\times(2)^2}{3} = 0.333 \text{ N.}$$

EXAMPLE 3.23

The Moon orbits the Earth once in 27.3 days in an almost circular orbit. Calculate the centripetal acceleration experienced by the Moon? (Radius of the Earth is 6.4×10^6 m)

Solution

The centripetal acceleration is given by $a = \frac{v^2}{r}$. This expression explicitly depends on Moon's speed which is non trivial. We can work with the formula

$$\omega^2 R_m = a_m$$

a_m is centripetal acceleration of the Moon due to Earth's gravity.

ω is angular velocity.

R_m is the distance between Earth and the Moon, which is 60 times the radius of the Earth.

$$R_m = 60R = 60 \times 6.4 \times 10^6 = 384 \times 10^6 \, m$$

As we know the angular velocity $\omega = \frac{2\pi}{T}$ and T = 27.3 days = 27.3 × 24 × 60 × 60 second = 2.358×10^6 sec

By substituting these values in the formula for acceleration

$$a_m = \frac{\left(4\pi^2\right)\left(384\times10^6\right)}{\left(2.358\times10^6\right)^2} = 0.00272 \text{ m s}^{-2}$$

The centripetal acceleration of Moon towards the Earth is 0.00272 m s^{-2}

Note This result was calculated by Newton himself. In unit 6 we will use this result.

3.7.2 Vehicle on a leveled circular road

When a vehicle travels in a curved path, there must be a centripetal force acting on it. This centripetal force is provided by the frictional force between tyre and surface of the road. Consider a vehicle of mass 'm' moving at a speed 'v' in the circular track of radius 'r'. There are three forces acting on the vehicle when it moves as shown in the Figure 3.43

1. Gravitational force (mg) acting downwards
2. Normal force (N) acting upwards
3. Frictional force (F_s) acting horizontally inwards along the road

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